

approach of peer assessments, particularly for more descriptive answers that cannot be easily evaluated by a computer. In Computer Science and Programming related courses, the participating Universities often employ external tools to evaluate coding-based assignments. For e.g. – Rice University uses the CodeSkulptor tool for running Python code within the browser, thus eliminating any platform dependencies in setting up one's programming environment.

While Coursera wasn't the first site to simulate the experience of a physical classroom, it has done a remarkable job of attracting the best professors from the most renowned universities to teach courses. The co-founder of Coursera, Andrew Ng, is a household name in the world of Artificial Intelligence, and he teaches the immensely popular Machine Learning course offered by Stanford University. Similarly, one of the scientists behind the MP3 audio format, Martin Vetterli of EPFL, Switzerland, teaches the course on Digital Signal Processing.

All courses offered by Coursera are free to take, though you also have the option of paying a fee (usually \$30 - \$100) to earn a Verified Certificate, which contains the University's and Coursera's affiliation, stating that you earned a passing grade on the course. More importantly, it confirms your identity by asking you to submit an Identity proof (such as a Driver's License) along with a photo of yourself taken using your computer's webcam. Additionally, you're also required to type out some sample text, which Coursera then uses as a sort of "digital fingerprint". You're required to type out this text at the end of each test as well to verify the legitimacy of the test. These Verified Certificates add a touch of authenticity to your resume, should you ever decide to list your Coursera courses.

Though Coursera gets most things right in the online education front, one aspect of the classroom experience it misses out on completely is feedback between the instructor and the student. Due to the sheer number of stu-



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